

Rivian's Boss Spills the Beans: Buttons Rule, Cybertruck Flops, and a Secret Plan!

From: Wired Gear Mined: 2026-06-14 3 min read

Have you ever seen a car with no buttons and thought, "How do I even turn on the radio?" Rivian's boss, RJ Scaringe, loves buttons. He says they just feel right. But his company makes **electric trucks** and SUVs, and they're in a wild race. They've lost billions of dollars, but they also got a huge **investment** from Volkswagen and Uber. Now, all eyes are on their new R2 SUV. It's supposed to be the car for everyone not too pricey, super cool. RJ admits if the R2 flops, they'd have to shrink the company big time. Why? Because they built giant parking lots, service centers, and even design their own **computer chips**, all expecting to sell tons of R2s. He also dished on other cars. The Tesla **Cybertruck**? "Very, very **niche**," he said. It's so wild-looking that it pushes people away. The Ferrari Luce? He thinks the inside is gorgeous, with amazing buttons and switches. And **Polestar**? Their cars look great but the price and features just haven't clicked with buyers. RJ's big dream is to give us more electric choices. Right now, two Teslas hog half the market. "That's not healthy," he says. "We need way more options!" So, will the R2 be the hero Rivian needs? Fingers crossed!

Word Treasure

electric trucks -- Pickup trucks that run on electricity instead of gasoline.

computer chips -- Tiny electronic brains that control how a car operates.

niche -- Something that appeals to only a small, specific group of people.

Cybertruck -- Tesla's unusual-looking electric pickup truck with a sharp, angular shape.

investment -- Money given to a company to help it grow, with the hope of earning more back later.

Polestar -- A car brand that makes stylish electric vehicles, but hasn't sold as well as expected.

Background you need

Rivian is an American electric vehicle company founded in 2009, best known for its R1T pickup truck and R1S SUV. RJ Scaringe (its founder and CEO) started the company with a dream of building adventure-ready electric vehicles.

Volkswagen, a giant German automaker, invested billions in Rivian, while Uber also put in money. Even so, Rivian has lost billions of dollars because building car factories and designing custom chips is very expensive.

The electric car market today is dominated by Tesla, but many experts and drivers want more brands to compete. That way, people can choose a car with the looks, features, and buttons they like.

Break it down

WHO: RJ Scaringe, the boss of electric truck and SUV maker Rivian.

WHAT: He shared his love for buttons, criticized the Cybertruck as too strange, and revealed that the future of his company depends on the R2 SUV's success.

WHERE: In a recent interview (no specific city mentioned).

WHY: Rivian spent a lot of money on factories and technology, and if the R2 flops, the company would have to shrink.

Why it matters

The cars you might drive someday could have buttons or touchscreens, and having more electric choices means better designs and prices for everyone.

Test what you remember

1. What does RJ Scaringe like in cars?

- ☐ (A) Touchscreens only
- ☐ (B) Buttons and switches
- ☐ (C) Voice controls
- ☐ (D) No controls at all

2. Which car did RJ call 'very, very niche'?

- ☐ (A) Rivian R2
- ☐ (B) Ferrari Luce
- ☐ (C) Tesla Cybertruck
- ☐ (D) Polestar

3. Why is the R2 SUV so important for Rivian?

- ☐ (A) It's their most expensive car
- ☐ (B) They built huge parking lots and service centers expecting to sell many R2s
- ☐ (C) It's the world's fastest SUV
- ☐ (D) It's the only car they make

4. What did RJ say about the electric car market?

- ☐ (A) It's perfectly balanced with many choices
- ☐ (B) Two Tesla models control half of it, which isn't healthy
- ☐ (C) Nobody wants electric cars anymore
- ☐ (D) Only trucks are popular

5. Which company gave Rivian a huge investment?

- ☐ (A) Ferrari
- ☐ (B) Tesla
- ☐ (C) Volkswagen and Uber
- ☐ (D) Polestar

6. What does RJ dream of for electric cars?

- ☐ (A) Having only one model for everyone
- ☐ (B) More choices so no single brand dominates
- ☐ (C) Returning to gasoline engines
- ☐ (D) Making cars without any computers

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **RJ Scaringe and Rivian fans:** They believe physical buttons are safer and more satisfying to use than touchscreens. They see the R2 as the car that will make electric adventure vehicles affordable and popular.
2. **Financial skeptics:** Some analysts worry Rivian's heavy spending and losses are too risky. If the R2 doesn't sell in huge numbers, the company might not survive, putting jobs and investors' money at risk.
3. **Tesla supporters:** Some people love the Cybertruck's futuristic look and think it's exactly what the market needs. They argue that Tesla's dominance proves it makes the best electric cars, and that 'niche' can still be highly successful.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):